

RHCD (Red Hat Certified Data Centre Specialist, RHCSS (Red Hat Certified Security Specialist) and RHCE (Red Hat Certified Engineer).

Varad Gupta, India's first RHCS and RHCA, who runs a Linux training academy called Fostering Linux, says: "The beauty with Red Hat is that it lays the foundation for a professional to climb the career ladder. RHCE (the entry-level Red Hat certification programme) is like your history textbook, wherein you learn about every dynasty. RHCE introduces an IT professional to every concept related to Linux. But just as students with a particular interest in Akbar would look up reference books on this famous king, once IT professionals have decided on their interests—security, data centre or networking, Red Hat allows you to dig deeper into these fields through its specialist certified programmes like RHCS for security, and so on."

However, Novell is fast catching up with Red Hat in providing a boost to a professional's career. Novell provides further specialisation through its training modules on Virtualisation and HA, Platespin for Virtualisation management, Access Manager for security, Intelligent Workload Management and Cloud Security services. "Our focus is on taking an individual through a journey from Linux to virtualisation, to the cloud, and offering all relevant training and certification of the highest quality, at an affordable price. This is part of Novell's vision of taking an individual from a Linux specialist to an all-round data centre specialist. We have a series of training modules and certifications that support an engineer through this journey," says Sandeep Menon, country head, Novell India.

Bali, who aspired to become a network and OS consultant/trainer, vouches for the career boost the Novell certification basket gave him. "I have not only conducted training and consultancy in India, but also the world over—and this was possible only due to my NCLP and NCLE certifications," says Bali. Maniyar vouches for the same. "My career goal in IT is making the best use of FOSS products, and creating solutions around them. NCLP added more to my career, since the SUSE

Whose line is it anyway?

A lot of confusion exists about what kind of professionals should choose NCLP or RHCE. While Novell is for a broader network of developers and the IT fraternity, Red Hat is more suited for administrators of IT infrastructure.

NCLP: For one and all

"Anyone wanting a career in the IT industry as a software professional would find the NCLP a great weapon to have in their repertoire of skills, especially aspiring 'systems administrators', developers, data centre managers, or those planning to work in the cloud computing space. Certifications like NCLP also provide students a background to gain competitive advantage, and to develop core skills to suit production environments in IT firms," says Menon.

RHCE: Focused target audience

"System administrators are the bulk of IT professionals who prefer the RHCE certification. Even database administrators who have Linux as their platform prefer an RHCE, to get a grip on the operating environment. Most importantly, RHCE is best suited for aspiring system and network administrators seeking work in mission-critical environments," says Bhaskaran.

market is ever-increasing and there is a deficit of NCLP-certified professionals as compared to RHCE. This made my career more secure, and opened a range of options for me."

Examination standards and training competency

With an eye on numbers, Red Hat has considerably diluted its examination standards over the years, leading to a glut of RHCEs, many of whom aren't well equipped to handle real industry jobs. On the other hand, Novell has maintained its examination standards, and has ensured that only suitable candidates get through their certification exams. "The new examination pattern of RHCE is much easier to crack compared to previous versions of the exam or the NCLP. The NCLP examination actually tests one's Linux solution designing, implementation and troubleshooting skill-sets," says Madhav.



"The Red Hat certification basket made me very confident of handling and solving even the most challenging situations."

—Tejas Sevak, an RHCA, RHCD, RHCS and RHCE



"Professionals planning their careers can opt for one vendor's certification first, and later on, add the other one."

—Rohit Aggarwal, CEO, Koenig Solutions